OCTOBER 2026 | VOLUME 7 ISSUE 12

FLORIDA FOOTBALL. ALWAYS.

GATORBAIT

MAGAZINE

NO. 17 FLORIDA VS. NO. 3 GEORGIA

Game Day edition. Saturday, Oct. 31, 3:30 p.m. ET, ABC. Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta.

BUDDY MARTIN
Sumrall Knows the Math

FRANZ BEARD
Thoughts of the Day

BRENDEN MARTIN
Snubbed in Atlanta

THE SHOW
Buddy, live for Georgia week

AP POLL
Florida Is No. 17

HALLOWEEN IN ATLANTA

GEORGIA WEEK

Sumrall's first Florida-Georgia, in a new city: Year 11 against Year One

Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media (file, Sept. 26, 2026)

THE GAME

NO. 17
FLORIDA
5-2 · 3-2 SEC

AT

NO. 3
GEORGIA
6-1 · 4-1 SEC

Saturday, Oct. 31 · 3:30 p.m. ET · ABC
Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta. Neutral site

Indoors. Artificial turf, per ESPN's venue listing. The game leaves Jacksonville for Atlanta this year and Tampa next while EverBank Stadium is renovated.

LINE	TOTAL	SERIES	ESPN MATCHUP PREDICTOR
Georgia -11.5	55.5	UF trails 44-57-2	Florida 17.9%

ESPN game summary and pickcenter (DraftKings), Oct. 27. Kickoff, TV and neutral site also on FloridaGators.com broadcast information, Oct. 27. Series count: FloridaGators.com opponent history.

FOUR KEYS

1. Baugh against the best run defense he has seen

Jadan Baugh has 763 yards and 13 touchdowns on 135 carries, and Florida runs for 194.3 a game. Georgia allows 90.3 rushing yards a game at 2.8 a carry, both the lowest figures on this page.

2. Third down, both ways

Georgia converts 54.0% of its third downs and holds opponents to 35.9%. Florida converts 44.6% and allows 43.7%. The Gators' defense has 22 sacks to Georgia's 22, and Georgia has allowed only 8.

3. Stockton against a pass defense that allows 255 a game

Gunner Stockton is 117 of 158 for 1,570 yards, 16 touchdowns and four interceptions; Georgia completes 71.6% at 9.7 yards an attempt. Florida allows 255.0 passing yards a game.

4. The quarterback Sumrall will not name

Aaron Philo is 105 of 149 for 1,341 yards, nine touchdowns and three interceptions this season; Tramell Jones Jr. made his first start in the 27-24 win at Texas. Sumrall said Monday he is not telling Georgia who starts. Dallas Wilson leads the receivers with 29 catches for 403 yards.

ESPN 2026 team statistics and game-summary leaders, Oct. 27 (both teams seven games). The quarterback line: Jon Sumrall's Monday press conference, as reported in Buddy Martin's column.

TALE OF THE TAPE

Season, per game: both teams through seven games

	FLORIDA	GEORGIA
Points scored	39.6	43
Total yards	450.9	469.9
Rushing yards	194.3	197.7
Yards a carry	4.8	6
Passing yards	256.6	272.1
Points allowed	28.3	15.9
Rush yards allowed	121.6	90.3
Pass yards allowed	255	185
Third down %	44.6	54
Opp. third down %	43.7	35.9
Sacks	22	22
Possession (minutes)	33	30.2

ESPN 2026 team statistics, Oct. 27. Points scored and allowed are figured from ESPN's final scores; possession minutes from ESPN's season possession seconds divided by games played.

THE SERIES

FIVE STRAIGHT FOR GEORGIA

FloridaGators.com counts the series at Georgia 57, Florida 44, two ties, starting in 1915. The Bulldogs have won the last five, all in Jacksonville, by a combined 177-87: 34-7 in 2021, 42-20 in 2022, 43-20 in 2023, 34-20 in 2024 and 24-20 last Nov. 1. Florida's last win was 44-28 in 2020; the Gators are 2-8 in the last 10.

AVAILABILITY

ESPN lists no injuries for either team as of Tuesday, Oct. 27. The official SEC availability report posts later in the week on FloridaGators.com.

BY THE NUMBERS

Six figures that frame Saturday

-11.5

GEORGIA, THE LINE

Total 55.5. DraftKings line via ESPN pickcenter, Oct. 27.

82.1%

ESPN PREDICTOR, GEORGIA

Florida at 17.9% in the ESPN matchup predictor.

L5

FLORIDA IN THE SERIES

Five straight Georgia wins. Florida's last was 44-28 in 2020. FloridaGators.com has the series at 44-57-2.

763

BAUGH RUSHING YARDS

Jadan Baugh: 135 carries, 13 touchdowns. Georgia allows 90.3 rushing yards a game at 2.8 a carry.

54.0%

GEORGIA ON THIRD DOWN

Florida's defense allows 43.7% on third down; the Florida offense converts 44.6%.

15.9

GEORGIA POINTS ALLOWED

A game, figured from ESPN's seven final scores. Florida scores 39.6 and allows 28.3.

ESPN game summary and pickcenter (event 401856734), ESPN 2026 team statistics and schedules, Oct. 27; FloridaGators.com series history.

WHAT WE'RE WATCHING

GatorBait Media writers, in their own words

> You can't buy what Georgia has. You have to grow it, and Georgia has been out there fertilizing since the Obama administration.
>
> **BUDDY MARTIN**

> Georgia has it. It is Sumrall's job to restore some sanity (that's from the Florida perspective) to the rivalry. More than half the players who will suit up for Florida Saturday have never played in this game.
>
> **FRANZ BEARD**

> In Buster's offense, Kirby explained, "it doesn't require the quarterback to be perfect." I would just like it printed somewhere large, preferably where a Florida locker room can see it all week.
>
> **BRENDEN MARTIN**

Lines from the writers' published columns on gatorbaitmedia.com, Oct. 26-27.

THE DESK · SATURDAY MATH

TWO SETS OF NUMBERS, ONE POINT SPREAD

The market says Georgia by 11.5. The season averages say something closer to a touchdown. Both can be true, and the gap between them is Saturday's story.

BY THE GATORBAIT MEDIA DESK

> **"THE AVERAGES SAY A TOUCHDOWN. THE LINE SAYS MORE."**

POINTS A GAME, SEASON AVERAGES (SEVEN GAMES EACH)



Georgia is favored by 11.5 at 3:30 p.m. ET on Saturday, and the total is 55.5. Do the arithmetic and the market is picturing something near Georgia 33.5, Florida 22.

Now put the season averages side by side. Florida scores 39.6 points a game. Georgia allows 15.9. Georgia scores 43.0. Florida allows 28.3. Split each matchup down the middle and you land at about 28 for Florida and 36 for Georgia. That is a touchdown and change, not 11.5. It is not a prediction. It is a reminder that the line and the stats are answering different questions. The line knows about a neutral site in Georgia's state capital, a five-game losing streak in the series and a Florida quarterback who has not been named. The averages do not.

Where the line has a case: Georgia's defense has given up 90.3 rushing yards a game at 2.8 a carry, and Florida's offense is built on Jadan Baugh's 763 yards. Georgia converts 54.0 percent of its third downs; Florida's defense allows 43.7. Georgia has allowed eight sacks all season. Florida has taken nine.

Where the averages have a case: Florida's 39.6 points a game include 44 at Auburn and 52 against Ole Miss, but the Gators have scored 27 or fewer in each of the last three games: 17 at Missouri, 19 against South Carolina, 27 at Texas. Georgia's lone loss came at home to Auburn, 27-24, the same Saturday Florida won in Austin.

The desk's view: the spread is about the quarterback question and the streak, not the stat sheet. If Florida's run game travels and the defense gets Georgia off the field on third down, the averages get a vote.

Line and total: DraftKings via ESPN pickcenter, Oct. 27. Points for and against figured from ESPN's final scores; rushing, third-down and sack figures from ESPN 2026 team statistics (seven games each), Oct. 27.

COVER STORY · BUDDY MARTIN

FLORIDA-GEORGIA: SUMRALL KNOWS THE MATH. HE'S JUST NOT TELLING GEORGIA WHO TAKES THE SNAP.

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 27, 2026



> **"KIRBY ISN'T RUNNING A FOOTBALL PROGRAM SO MUCH AS A FAMILY FARM."**

Orange and blue on one side, red and black on the other: Florida and Georgia fans split the stands in Jacksonville in 2008. This year the game moves to Atlanta, where the split may look more like 60-40, Bulldogs.

Photo by jasonduhon, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons. Original photograph, unaltered.

You can't buy what Georgia has. You have to grow it.

Georgia week usually brings out the worst in a football coach. He puffs his chest, praises the opponent's long snapper and swears it's just another game, which is like saying Halloween is just another Saturday. This one happens to fall on Halloween, which seems about right.

Jon Sumrall skipped the theater Monday. He walked into the room and handed over something Gator fans may not want to hear: a scouting report on why the Bulldogs are who they are, and why Florida isn't. Not yet, anyway.

"I think it's year 11 for Kirby there," Sumrall said. "You can tell they have layered development."

Layered. Like a wedding cake, or a lasagna, or the debt Florida has piled up in this series. Georgia recruited great players "year-in, year-out." They developed them. They're "calloused," "strong" and "physical," and all of it, Sumrall said, has "been built over time."

Translation: You can't buy what Georgia has. You have to grow it, and Georgia has been out there fertilizing since the Obama administration.

GEORGIA, GEORGIA, GEORGIA

"Georgia, Georgia, Georgia, Georgia," Sumrall said.

No, this was not Sumrall trying to invoke that Ray Charles classic as a singer. It was just a dose of pure reality.

He did his bye-week homework on Georgia's personnel report, the sheet that lists each player's previous school. Down the Bulldogs' list, over and over, the previous school was the same school. Kirby isn't running a football program so much as a family farm.

"When we can become that," Sumrall said, "is when you… create consistency."

Now flip to Florida's sheet. Roughly half the Gators were here last year. The other half just showed up from a high school or somewhere else, a few of them probably still asking where the cafeteria is.

"They're in Year 11," Sumrall said. "We're in Year One."

That's not an excuse. It's arithmetic.

Every Gator fan who has watched Georgia treat this game like a standing dinner reservation needs to learn the math.

NEVER AGAIN 3

Sumrall didn't sugarcoat his first winter. Florida hit the transfer portal "just to be able to field a football team that could practice."

Not to win a championship. To practice. That's like shopping for a car so you'll have something to park in the driveway.

December and January were a minefield. Players he thought were staying left, and players he figured were gone stayed.

"You didn't know where you were going to step and what was going to blow up on you," he said.

Welcome to modern college football, where the roster has a revolving door and every agent has a cell phone.

His plan from here sounds almost quaint: Recruit high school kids. Develop them. Keep them. Use the portal for six to 10 difference-makers a year to plug real holes, not to restock the whole pantry.

"It better never again be high 20s, 30s," he said, "or we got a real problem."

He also noted that Georgia doesn't shop the portal for backups.

When the Dawgs have a need, they go get a great player like Isiah Canion.

"They don't go out and just go to the portal to get a third-string guy," Sumrall said.

Some programs shop at Neiman Marcus. Others hit the clearance rack hoping for a 46 long.

Then came the line of the day, on Georgia linebacker Chris Cole, whom Kirby has been raving about: "If I had Chris Cole on my roster, I'd be raving about retaining him too."

THE ONE-YEAR FLIP

Nobody in Gainesville gets misty-eyed over "process." Gator fans want to hear about process the way they want to hear about root canals. Sumrall knows it, so he tried to have it both ways.

"They didn't just do a one-year flip," he said of Georgia. "They've done a build from the ground up. And I want a one-year flip, too. I want to win every day."

Don't we all, coach. Don't we all.

He admitted his short-term plan has been hit-and-miss: "some of it's gone well, some of it hasn't." The record agrees.

An upset of then-No. 4 Ole Miss. Back-to-back losses to Missouri and South Carolina. Then a 27-24 win at Texas that lifted the Gators to No. 17.

One week they look like world-beaters, the next week they're beating themselves. That's a year-one team.

THE QUARTERBACK SHELL GAME

Then came the question everybody really came for: Aaron Philo or Tramell Jones Jr.?

Sumrall answered it the way a politician answers a question about taxes.

"Both guys are available. Believe in both guys," he said. "Not going to name a starter today… We need both those guys to be ready to play."

He'll decide "middleish of the week," probably Wednesday. And don't wait by the fax machine.

"There's not going to be a big QB1 announcement for this game or any game," he said.

Why all the secrecy? Start with health. Philo, the Georgia Tech transfer who started the first six games, is coming back from the shoulder injury that sidelined him at Texas. Jones, who won his first career start in Austin, came out of it with "wear-and-tear" injuries. Both practiced Monday, and Sumrall says how they hold up "matters."

But let's not be naive. Making Georgia prepare for two quarterbacks costs Florida nothing but a little sleep.

Philo is the polished passer: 70.5 percent completions, nine touchdowns, three picks. Jones is the sophomore who hit a fourth-and-12 throw and ran for the game-sealing first down at Texas.

Kirby is already treating it as a two-man problem.

"One beat Ole Miss handedly and one beat Texas on the road," Smart said, adding that Buster Faulkner "can play to the strengths of each guy."

That's exactly what Sumrall wants. Let Georgia's defensive staff stay up late watching two guys.

And there's a little extra seasoning: Philo, the former Prince Avenue Christian star, holds Georgia's high school passing record. Imagine the home-state kid beating the Dawgs in their own capital city.

TV TV TV TV TV

Watch: Sumrall on Florida's quarterback decision — Monday's press conference, via Gator Bait Media.

GET YOUR FILTHY HANDS OFF IT

And now a word from our sponsor. Or rather, a word against them.

This year's game has an official name, Gawd help us: the Invesco QQQ Atlanta Gridiron Classic.

That's how it reads on the stadium's event page and the ticket listings. It sounds like an index fund that sponsors a charity 10K.

Somewhere a marketing VP got a bonus for that, and somewhere Bill Kastelz, the Times-Union sports editor who coined the Cocktail Party name, is spinning like a rotisserie chicken.

We know what this game is. It's Florida-Georgia. Or Georgia-Florida, depending on the year and your bloodline. It was the World's Largest Outdoor Cocktail Party until the college presidents got squeamish, and every fan with a cooler kept calling it that anyway. It has belonged to Jacksonville nearly every year since 1933, and it'll go back there in 2028.

Corporate America's attempt to gussy it up may muddy the fender a little. It won't wreck the car. Florida-Georgia is stronger than all this corporate filth that passes for branding, or rebranding.

So please, please, please. Get your filthy hands off of it.

THE VERDICT

Sumrall doesn't sound like a coach making excuses. He sounds like one who has studied the opponent closely and is honest about how far Florida has to go. In this business, honesty is rarer than a Georgia fan who doesn't bring up the scoreboard.

Georgia is coming off a home loss to Auburn, which should make the Dawgs about as cheerful as a wet cat.

The tickets are split down the middle on paper, but in Atlanta the crowd may turn out more like 60-40, Bulldogs. Call it a semi-home game with a neutral-site invoice.

The Bulldogs are still the Bulldogs, built layer by layer over a decade. Sumrall has one year of layers.

On Saturday, we find out if that's enough, or if Florida's going to get the Ray Charles treatment again: Georgia on its mind, all the way home.

THE LEAD · FRANZ BEARD

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY: SUMRALL'S FIRST FLORIDA-GEORGIA

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 27, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Photo: Florida coach Jon Sumrall on the field before the Gators' Sept. 26, 2026, game against Ole Miss at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium. File photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

"I think anybody that says it's just another game doesn't have a real good pulse of what reality is in college football or to our fan base."

Jon Sumrall said that Monday at his press conference at the Heavener Football Center in Gainesville, a combination of excitement and reverence showing on his face and in his demeanor. Saturday at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta (3:30 p.m., ABC) will be his first Florida-Georgia game. The fact that the game will be played somewhere other than Jacksonville, the long-standing traditional home of the rivalry game does nothing to dampen his enthusiasm or his understanding of what winning this game means.

It is more, much more, than border state bragging rights and the importance goes far beyond two ranked teams squaring off, both of them very much in the hunt for a second trip to Atlanta this season for the SEC Championship Game and beyond that, the College Football Playoff. For the 17th-ranked Gators (5-2, 3-2 SEC), a loss would jeopardize their chances of making the SEC Championship Game for the first time since 2020 and reaching the College Football Playoff for the first time. The four-team playoff introduced in 2014 expanded to 12 teams in 2024. For No. 3 Georgia (6-1, 4-1 SEC), it is a matter of keeping up with the SEC Joneses, in this case the rather surprising Kentucky Wildcats (7-1, 5-1 SEC). Since 2011 Georgia has played for the SEC championship 10 times, winning four, all of them since Kirby Smart became the head coach. The Bulldogs broke a 41-year national championship drought in 2021 and repeated in 2022.

HOW THE RIVALRY CHANGED

There was a time when the roles were reversed and Florida was the dominant team. Steve Spurrier went 11-1 against Georgia, won six SEC championships and the 1996 national title. Ron Zook won two out of three and might have had a perfect record against the Bulldogs except he was fired on the Monday before the 2004 Florida-Georgia game. Urban Meyer was 5-1 against Georgia, winning both SEC and national championships in 2006 and 2008.

Since Florida's 21-year dominance that began in Spurrier's first year on the job in 1990, the Gators have been a revolving door of coaches. Sumrall, in his first year on the job, is the fifth head coach since Meyer took a hiatus after the 2010 season. Georgia, meanwhile, has been the picture of stability. Mark Richt took over the Georgia program from Jim Donnan in 2001, and won two SEC championships in 15 years, going 5-10 against the Gators. Richt was fired and Georgia native son Kirby Smart took over the program in 2016. Since then Georgia is 123-22. In his 11th season on the job, Smart is 8-2 against the Gators, losing only the 2016 and 2020 games.

What Georgia has going for it is momentum, which only adds to the history and significance of Florida-Georgia. For Florida fans who remember the good old days from 1990-2010, what Georgia has done under Kirby Smart is a painful reminder of what happens when there is a confluence of good coaching, exceptional recruiting and stability at the top.

Georgia has it. It is Sumrall's job to restore some sanity (that's from the Florida perspective) to the rivalry. More than half the players who will suit up for Florida Saturday have never played in this game. They came to Florida from the transfer portal or as wide-eyed freshmen. Georgia's program under Smart has grown to a point of using the portal only to add a few impact players each year. Nearly the entire roster is home grown.

"Georgia the way they've done it and the way they've got it built now, they don't go out and just go to the portal to get a third-string guy," Sumrall said, adding "Most of their roster is because they've done a good job of layering. Our roster, there's a lot of guys playing Saturday, I'm teaching them what this game needs to mean to us. And we haven't had a recent history of the success we need to have in this rivalry to make it as competitive as it should be."

To put that in perspective, Georgia has won five consecutive games against Florida. The Gators last beat the Bulldogs in 2020.

Sumrall spent the bye week balancing the history and traditions that have always made this one of the great rivalry games in the country with what has to happen for the Gators to get their third win over a top-ten ranked team this season. Georgia enters as the higher-ranked team.

"First, you want to make sure they understand it is a rivalry game," Sumrall said. "They need to have awareness of that. And then you have to bring it back to, while there's all this heightened publicity around the game, it's still a football game and what wins football games. So you have to lean on both. You can't just be all hype about highlight videos and the history of the game, without, hey, here are the plays we're gonna run, here's how we're gonna block them, here's the progression of the quarterback, here's where we're trying to tackle him, here's what we're trying to do on defense to slow them down. That's the stuff that really matters. But I do think the guys need to understand that the game has, it counts for one game on your record, but it has a different feel."

A different feel, yes, when the Florida discussion has everything to do with traditions and the recent history of the game that highly favors Georgia. Smart, who was on the losing side in Athens the last time Florida-Georgia had to take a vacation from Jacksonville due to stadium issues, can speak to his team from a personal perspective. He was on the field when Eric Kresser threw a touchdown pass to Travis McGriff to finish off the Gators' 52-17 win over Georgia in 1995, the first time an opposing team had ever hung 50 or more on the Bulldogs at Sanford Stadium. He was also on the only Georgia team that beat Spurrier in 1997.

BUILDING A ROSTER FOR THE RIVALRY

And now, Smart is the driving force for an era of Georgia dominance. For Sumrall to change the momentum of the rivalry, he has to build a roster that is Georgia-like in that it is mostly home grown and stacked with talent so that when one player goes down due to injury a player of equal or greater talent is next man up. When a Georgia player leaves for the NFL as so many do, Smart cherry picks from the portal.

"I actually studied their roster some during the bye week because I do think they've been really consistent," Sumrall said. "And when you look through our personnel reports that we do on each team as we get ready to go into a game week, it tells us previous school – whether you know high school, college slash high school. These guys have a lot of guys' previous school from a college standpoint, it was Georgia. So I think as you get to the model, like year one of our program, a lot of our guys on their previous school it says somewhere other than Florida.

"We retained a good number of players: roughly half our roster were here last year, but the other half was not. So half of our roster says the high school they just came from, or a different school and so I think as you build, and like I said earlier, they're in year 11, we're in year one. As you build in year four, five, six, seven, whatever, you start to move forward. In a perfect world in the portal year and year out, you're adding six to 10 difference makers. In some years, it might be five or might be 12, so I'm not locking myself into like, hey, we're only adding six to 10 every year. Some years it might be five. Some years it might have to be 12 or 13. It better never again be high 20s, 30s, or we got a real problem. So as you build your roster, you want to add portal pieces that are like frontline starters when you have immediate glaring needs and holes. This past year, we had to go out and get guys out of the portal just to be able to field a football team that could practice. Never again will that be the case here, I hope."

It shouldn't be lost on anyone that Florida comes into this game with the momentum of a 27-24 win over Texas, which just two weeks before had been ranked No. 1. Georgia spent a week at the top following the Texas loss to Oklahoma that knocked the Longhorns out of the top spot, but in their first game after ascending to No. 1, the Bulldogs were stunned by unranked Auburn, 27-24. Yes, the same team that Florida beat 44-39 in Auburn whacked Georgia in Athens.

With a win, Florida keeps hope alive. With a loss, Georgia is still very much in the hunt for the SEC Championship Game and the playoff.

So, much is at stake Saturday, which is the way it should be. Great rivalry games deserve far reaching consequences and Florida-Georgia has them. By no means is this just another game.

THE BIG PICTURE · BRENDEN MARTIN

SNUBBED IN ATLANTA: GAMEDAY PASSED, KIRBY SHRUGGED, FLORIDA NOTICED

College GameDay went to Bloomington, Kirby Smart called Florida's quarterbacks "completely capable," and the rivalry moved 70 miles from his campus. Brenden Martin reads the transcripts.

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 27, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Photo: Florida and Georgia players battle during their Nov. 2, 2024, meeting in Jacksonville. File photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

I am not a detective. I read college football press conference transcripts for a living, which is a worse job and, this week, nearly the same one.

Because something about this Florida-Georgia week does not add up, and it is not the point spread.

Begin with the smallest mystery. ESPN's College GameDay is a show that travels the country looking for the biggest game in America, and this week it found one in Bloomington, Indiana, where the Hoosiers will host Minnesota. Minnesota is 5-2. The Gophers are a perfectly respectable football team, the kind you are happy to see on your schedule in November, preferably at noon, preferably already over. Indiana is the defending national champion and ranked No. 4, so the show is not crazy. It is just not at our game, and our game is Florida and Georgia, in Atlanta, for the first time in the modern history of the rivalry.

Georgia, for the record, has already been on the show this year. GameDay went to Tuscaloosa for Georgia and Alabama in Week 6. The Bulldogs have had their close-up. It was the rivalry itself, a hundred years old and temporarily homeless, that got left at the curb in a nice suit. The SEC's own pregame show will be in Atlanta on Saturday morning, Tim Tebow and all. The big one will be at a fountain in Bloomington.

KIRBY'S QUARTERBACK ASSESSMENT

Which brings us to the main witness. Kirby Smart met the media on Monday, and I have now read his remarks three times. This tells you nothing good about my social life and a great deal about his adjectives.

Kirby was warm about nearly everyone. Jon Sumrall has brought energy and physicality to Florida. The coordinators have his respect. Buster Faulkner, once an assistant on Kirby's own staff, was introduced like family at a reunion: one of the best offensive minds in the country, a close friend, respect upon respect. If compliments were currency, Buster could retire.

Then Kirby arrived at Florida's quarterbacks. He called Aaron Philo and Tramell Jones Jr. "very talented" and "good players," credited their wins and said Faulkner can play to their strengths. Fair enough. But a man has to know what he heard, and what I heard was "completely capable," followed by "plenty capable." The way you describe a rental car. It has four wheels. It runs. It is completely capable of reaching the airport.

Oh, and just one more thing. In Buster's offense, Kirby explained, "it doesn't require the quarterback to be perfect."

There it is. Everything else in that press conference was a man being gracious. To my ear, that sentence sounded more revealing than the compliments. He respects the machine. The two young men operating it, the ones who beat Ole Miss and Texas, are simply the help. Kirby even recited their accomplishments himself, both wins, out loud, and then handed them the same word you would use for a hotel shower with decent water pressure.

I do not blame him for saying it. I would just like it printed somewhere large, preferably where a Florida locker room can see it all week.

Kirby had one more opinion worth writing down, this one about the game leaving Jacksonville this year and landing in Atlanta, about 70 miles from his campus. He does not think the venue matters much to the teams, he said. For the fans, the game in the 'Benz will probably be a unique experience.

Isn't that generous. A unique experience. The neutral site in this rivalry just moved into Georgia's state capital, into a dome my dad figures will split something like 60-40 for the Bulldogs, and the head coach of the Bulldogs has studied the situation and concluded that geography is a non-issue. I believe he believes that. If my commute to the biggest game of my season were that short, I would find geography pretty uninteresting myself.

Jacksonville, for all its humidity and questionable stadium food, had one virtue that can never be replaced. Georgia did not own it. Nobody owned it. That was the entire arrangement, and it survived for the better part of a century because both sides understood the value of a room neither family controlled. This year the room has an Atlanta address and a corporate name, and half the sport has decided not to notice.

Look at the evidence. The national stage went to Indiana. The opposing coach praised our play-caller like a brother and our quarterbacks like appliances. The neutral site leans red, the polls have Florida at No. 17 in one and No. 20 in the other.

THE PATTERN AFTER A BYE WEEK

One final detail, and then I will let everyone go. Kirby Smart has lost back-to-back regular-season games exactly twice in 11 seasons at Georgia, both times in his first season, 2016. The last time it happened, the order went like this: a loss, a bye week, and then a 24-10 loss to Florida.

Georgia's last game was a 27-24 loss at home to Auburn. Auburn's quarterback ran for 115 yards on that defense, and Florida, earlier this season, scored 44 on Auburn. Georgia has since had its bye week. I am not saying history repeats itself. Detectives deal in facts, and the fact is simply that the pattern is sitting there on the table where anybody can look at it.

Florida has Vernell Brown III back at practice, with Sumrall optimistic about his possible return, Jadan Baugh to lean on and a defense that already won once this month in a stadium where it was not wanted. Sumrall still will not name his quarterback, which means Georgia's staff gets to spend the week preparing for two capable young men and one uncomfortable sentence from their own head coach.

We are one sovereign Gator Nation. See you in Atlanta, where the venue does not matter, the quarterbacks are capable and absolutely nothing suspicious is going on.

Florida and Georgia kick off at 3:30 p.m. EDT Saturday on ABC at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta.

SATURDAY IN THE SEC

Five SEC games on Halloween. Kickoffs and TV: ESPN scoreboard. All times ET. The Soothsayer's picks post Friday on gatorbaitmedia.com.

TIME (ET)	GAME	TV	LINE
12:45 p.m.	Auburn (4-3) at No. 12 Ole Miss (5-2)	SEC Network	MISS -13.5 · O/U 57.5
3:30 p.m.	**No. 17 Florida (5-2) at No. 3 Georgia (6-1)** Neutral site, Atlanta	**ABC**	**UGA -11.5 · O/U 55.5**
4:15 p.m.	South Carolina (4-3) at Oklahoma (4-3)	SEC Network	OU -5.5 · O/U 44.5
7:30 p.m.	Mississippi State (4-3) at No. 11 Texas (5-2)	ESPN	TEX -21 · O/U 50.5
7:45 p.m.	No. 23 Missouri (5-2) at Arkansas (3-4)	SEC Network	MIZ -10 · O/U 49.5

Kickoffs, TV, records, rankings and DraftKings lines: ESPN SEC scoreboard for Oct. 31 and the AP Top 25 (Week 9), read Oct. 27. Alabama, Kentucky, LSU, Tennessee, Texas A&M and Vanderbilt are idle.

HOW TO WATCH

KICKOFF	Saturday, Oct. 31, 3:30 p.m. ET
TV	ABC (Chris Fowler, Kirk Herbstreit, Holly Rowe)
STREAM	ESPN app (ESPN on ABC), with a TV-provider login
RADIO	Gator Sports Network, pregame from 12:15 p.m. ET; SiriusXM 145 and the SiriusXM app; ESPN Gainesville WRUF and The Varsity Network
PREGAME TV	SEC Nation from Atlanta on Saturday morning
WHERE	Mercedes-Benz Stadium, Atlanta. Neutral site

Sources: FloridaGators.com broadcast information (Oct. 27) and SEC Nation announcement (Oct. 24); ESPN game summary

BRENDEN MARTIN · WATCH

WE'RE LIVE: FLORIDA-GEORGIA TALK ON THE BUDDY MARTIN SHOW

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 27, 2026



Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White

Photo: Jon Sumrall celebrates with Florida players after the Oct. 17 win at Texas. File photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

The Buddy Martin Show is live Monday night, Oct. 26, with Florida-Georgia week on the agenda. Join Buddy for the conversation about Jon Sumrall's quarterback decision and the week ahead for the Gators.

WATCH THE SHOW LIVE

Tonight's episode, "Florida Gators: Sumrall Won't Name a QB for Georgia," is streaming on The Buddy Martin Show's YouTube channel. Tap the watch link above to open the broadcast directly.

MORE FROM BUDDY

Read Buddy's new column: Florida-Georgia: Sumrall Knows the Math. He's Just Not Telling Georgia Who Takes the Snap.

Keep this article handy for the link to tonight's episode.

Photo courtesy UAA (University Athletic Association, FloridaGators.com) and Hannah White. See more of her work on Instagram, and the official Florida Gators photo galleries at FloridaGators.com.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/buddy-martin-show-live-florida-georgia-october-26-2026

FRANZ BEARD · THOUGHTS OF THE DAY

THOUGHTS OF THE DAY: OCTOBER 26, 2026

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 26, 2026



Illustration: GatorBait Media

Illustration: GatorBait Media (AI-assisted).

A few thoughts to jump start your Monday morning:

That the Georgia Bulldogs are favored to beat the Florida Gators when the rivalry takes the first of a two-year vacation from its traditional home in Jacksonville is no surprise. The Bulldogs (6-1, 4-1 SEC) should be favored. They are ranked third in the latest Associated Press poll and have spent the year being touted as one of a handful of teams capable of running the College Football Playoff table to a national championship. Georgia's lone loss to Auburn is being dismissed as nothing more than a speed bump. Obviously, the people who set the point spreads in Las Vegas share that belief, otherwise why else would they establish the Bulldogs as 10.5-point favorites to overwhelm 17th-ranked Florida (5-2, 3-2 SEC) Saturday (3:30 p.m., ABC) at Atlanta's Mercedes-Benz Stadium?

It is a familiar narrative for Florida. Just a couple of weeks ago, the Gators opened the week as 10.5-point road underdogs to Texas. The spread swelled to 11.5 points by gametime in Austin. No way a Florida team that fell victim to spinning toe holds, atomic elbow drops and at least one reverse vertical suplex in consecutive losses to Missouri and South Carolina could hang with the mighty Longhorns, right?

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/thoughts-of-the-day-october-26-2026

BRENDEN MARTIN · GAME WEEK

FLORIDA-GEORGIA WEEK: ATLANTA KICKOFF, QUARTERBACK WATCH AND FAN PLANS

BY BRENDEN MARTIN Oct. 25, 2026



Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White

Florida and Georgia return from open dates Saturday, Oct. 31, with their annual rivalry moving to Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta. Kickoff is set for 3:30 p.m. ET on ABC, giving Gators fans a week to follow the quarterback story and plan for a different game-day destination.

Florida is 5-2 overall and 3-2 in the SEC. Georgia is 6-1 and 4-1. Both last played Oct. 17: Florida won 27-24 at Texas, while Kirby Smart's Bulldogs lost 27-24 at home to Auburn.

Monday's first public stop is Gator Talk. Florida coach Jon Sumrall joins broadcaster Sean Kelley from 7-8 p.m. at The Swamp Restaurant, 1104 SW Second Ave. in Gainesville. Fans can attend or listen through Gator Sports Network affiliates, the Florida Gators app or the Varsity Network app.

Tramell Jones Jr. supplies the backdrop for this week's quarterback coverage. In his first college start at Texas, Jones completed 22 of 35 passes for 155 yards and two touchdowns and ran for 41 yards. UF's Oct. 21 account said Jones started after Aaron Philo was sidelined by a shoulder injury.

"I'm proud of him for staying resilient," Sumrall said after the Texas win.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/florida-georgia-week-atlanta-kickoff-quarterback-watch-and-fan-plans

BUDDY MARTIN

THE NINTH GAME IS COLLECTING ITS TOLL, ONE BODY AT A TIME

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 25, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Florida-Georgia used to be about who wanted it more. On Oct. 31 in Atlanta, it may come down to who has more players who can still walk without a limp.

They called it the World's Largest Outdoor Cocktail Party. This year it may be the World's Largest Outdoor Training Room. Bring your own ice.

In Gainesville, the bye week showed up like a cold towel on a hot neck. Florida (5-2, 3-2 SEC) beat No. 7 Texas, then spent Saturday on the couch. Best break Jon Sumrall has caught all month.

The Gators were ranked 17th in the latest AP poll. Miami held on to the No. 1 ranking.

THIS WEEK'S AP TOP 25

1. Miami (Fla.)
2. Ohio State
3. Georgia
4. Indiana
5. Notre Dame
6. Utah
7. UCLA
8. BYU
9. Kentucky
10. Alabama
11. Texas
12. Ole Miss
13. Texas Tech
14. Wake Forest
15. LSU
16. Tennessee
17. Florida
18. Houston
19. SMU
20. Boise State (tie)
20. Northwestern (tie)
22. Arizona
23. Missouri
24. Oklahoma State

25. Wisconsin

FLORIDA'S INJURY PICTURE

Aaron Philo took a shot to his throwing shoulder against South Carolina. Sumrall called it a "couple week deal," and Philo is questionable. Meanwhile, Tramell Jones Jr. made his first career start and beat the seventh-ranked team in the country. Sumrall hasn't announced who starts.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/the-ninth-game-is-collecting-its-toll-one-body-at-a-time

FRANZ BEARD

THE GATORS STILL HAVE A PULSE AFTER SATURDAY'S CHAOS

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 25, 2026



Illustration: GatorBait Media

The obituary was being penned and haggling had begun to get the right price for the coffin. That was three weeks ago when plans were in progress to lay Florida's 2026 football season to rest. That was before all hell broke loose not only in the Southeastern Conference but in college football nationwide.

The Gators beat Texas, Auburn beat Georgia and Tennessee beat Alabama. That was two Saturdays ago when the Gators rediscovered their pulse and suddenly found themselves back in contention for both the SEC Championship Game and the College Football Playoff.

The Gators' chances got a boost yesterday when both Ole Miss and Tennessee were tagged with their second loss, leaving upstart Kentucky and Georgia as the only one-loss teams in the conference. The Gators are among the eight teams still in contention with two losses. For Florida and everyone else in the pack every game from here on out is an elimination game.

The way things are shaping up for the playoff the only way a three-loss team makes it to the College Football Playoff is to suffer the third loss in the conference championship game.

Prior to Saturday's chaos, the 12-team CFP was shaping up for three teams each from the SEC, Big Ten and Big 12 with the bracket filled out by Miami, Notre Dame and the highest rated conference champ from the Group of Six.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/the-gators-still-have-a-pulse-after-saturdays-chaos

FRANZ BEARD · THOUGHTS OF THE DAY

SUMRALL RESTORES HOPE AS TEXAS FACES A RECKONING

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 24, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

File photo: Jon Sumrall on the Florida sideline against Ole Miss at Ben Hill Griffin Stadium on Sept. 26, 2026. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Thoughts of the Day | Oct. 24, 2026

A few thoughts to jump-start your Saturday morning:

Confession time. In the privacy of your own home with no one to witness, raise your hand if you thought two weeks ago that the Florida Gators would be most fortunate to limp home with a 6-6 regular season? Losing to Missouri and South Carolina in thank you sir may I have another fashion will do that to you.

Memories of Mizzou and South Carolina are in the rearview after the upset of Texas in Austin and the bye week has provided necessary time for Florida's walking wounded to heal up in time for the five-week gauntlet ahead. Have the last two weeks pumped hope back into the collective mindset of the Gator Nation? Or, is it because next up is Georgia next Saturday in Atlanta that you are tempering your expectations?

Fair questions that deserve honest answers.

Bunch me in with the doubters, especially after the way the Gators were skewered and rotisseried by the Gamecocks at The Swamp. Losing to Missouri wasn't necessarily a surprise given the way the Gators seem to always dial up crappy when they travel to Columbia. Even a 28-point loss could be rationalized to a certain degree. But blown out by the Chickens on national TV in The Swamp?

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/thoughts-of-the-day-october-24-2026

FRANZ BEARD · THE SOOTHSAYER

GATORS HEAL FOR GEORGIA AS THE SEC SOOTHSAYER MAKES HIS PICKS

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 23, 2026



Collage: GatorBait Media; photos by Chris Spears and courtesy UAA and Hannah White

Vernell Brown III at The Swamp, and Tramell Jones Jr. handing off to Jadan Baugh against Texas in Austin. Brown photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media; Jones/Baugh photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White. Editorial collage by GatorBait Media.

Thoughts of the Day · October 23, 2026

A few thoughts to jump start your Friday morning:

Traditionally, both Florida and Georgia have a bye week prior to their close encounter, usually in Jacksonville but in Atlanta this year, Tampa next while EverBank Stadium is renovated. No one could have possibly foreseen just how perfect the timing of the bye week would be for Jon Sumrall, whose 20th-ranked Gators (5-2, 3-2 SEC) have used the open date to heal their banged up wide receiver corps. Getting Vernell Brown III, Eric Singleton Jr. and Bailey Stockton as close to full speed as possible enhances the Gators' chances to spring the upset on the 5th-ranked Bulldogs (6-1, 4-1 SEC), who were exposed as vulnerable by Auburn, a team the Gators beat.

The extra week also benefits Florida quarterback Aaron Philo, who took a blow to his throwing shoulder in the loss to South Carolina and missed the Gators' upset of Texas. It is said to be either a bruised or sprained AC joint. Best-case scenario for healing: three to four weeks. Worst case, out the rest of the year. The game at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta will be week three in the healing process. Enough time for Philo to be healthy enough to play? Only time will answer that question.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/thoughts-of-the-day-october-23-2026

BUDDY MARTIN · SEC LEGENDS

FROM THE SCOUT TEAM TO ATLANTA: CHRIS DOERING FINALLY GETS HIS DUE

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 23, 2026



Photo: UAA/SEC

He left in 1995 with 31 touchdown catches, still the school record and second in SEC history. Think about the receivers who have come through Gainesville since then

By Buddy Martin

They used to hand Chris Doering a scout-team jersey and tell him to go get hit. He'd take the beating, show up the next day, and take it again. No scholarship or promise came with it, and nobody in Gainesville was printing his name in the program.

He was a skinny kid from P.K. Yonge whose dream was bigger than his resume. Thirty-five years later, that kid is an SEC Legend. Doering was named Thursday last week to the 2026 SEC Football Legends class.

It's a 16-member group full of Heisman Trophy winners, national champions and NFL stars: Nick Saban of Alabama, Mark Richt of Georgia, Billy Sims of Oklahoma, Patrick Peterson of LSU, Randall Cobb of Kentucky and Ricky Williams of Texas.

The walk-on is standing in that crowd. Tell me this game doesn't still make room for a good story.

"THE SCARLET LETTER"

You have to understand how much that label stung. "I hated being called a walk-on," Doering told me on The Buddy Martin Show. "It was such a scarlet letter to me. It always felt like it was just less than everybody else. So I wanted that validation of having a scholarship. It meant more to me when I finally got it."

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/from-the-scout-team-to-atlanta-chris-doering-finally-gets-his-due

BUDDY MARTIN

GATOR FOOTBALL FEEL-GOOD: THE OPEN DATE IS SWEET MUSIC, BUT CHECK THE LYRICS

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 21, 2026



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media

Two words on a football schedule don't mean much to most people: "Open Date." To a normal citizen it's a blank square on the calendar. It's a fine Saturday for a wedding, a trip to the mountains or finally cleaning the gutters.

But if your life is built around a football team, those two words sound like a Merle Haggard ballad drifting out of a jukebox. Sweet, a little sad and exactly what you needed to hear.

For Jon Sumrall, this week is that song.

His Gators have played seven straight Saturdays. They've been to the mountaintop, No. 8 in the country after running Ole Miss out of the Swamp 52-28.

They've been in the ditch beside it, falling out of the poll after a homecoming loss to South Carolina. Then last weekend they went to Austin, where the barbecue smoke hangs over the interstate and nobody expects the visitors to leave happy, and beat No. 7 Texas 27-24.

That's a season's worth of mood swings in seven weeks. A team needs a nap.

So this Saturday in Gainesville, the practice fields will be quiet and the training room will be full. It'll be ice tubs instead of film sessions. Somewhere a backup linebacker will sleep until noon and call it the best thing to happen to him since signing day.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/gator-football-feel-good-the-open-date-is-sweet-music-but-check-the-lyrics

FRANZ BEARD

JONES VS. PHILO AND OTHER QB PERCEPTIONS, REALITIES

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 21, 2026



Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White

Cover photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

Nowhere in collegiate sports are the expectations higher than they are for quarterbacks tagged with a fifth star, most often by a recruiting analyst who might have been a star in the co-ed intramural flag football league back in the day. Five stars projects the perception of greatness even before the first collegiate snap is taken. It also projects the greatest perception of bust for those who don't measure up to expectations that range from stratospheric to walks on water.

Talent alone is no guarantor for success at quarterback, where borderline insane expectations have to deal with the reality of the greatest risk and overall the fewest rewards. Nationally since 2015 there have been 38 quarterbacks with a 5-star rating (per 247Sports) of which it could be said that seven performed up to or beyond expectations. The two 5-stars signed by the Florida Gators during that span – Feleipe Franks and DJ Lagway – had pockets of success before transferring out.

The quarterback under the most scrutiny at present and perhaps since some keyboard cowboy came up with star ratings is Arch Manning, described as a generational talent when he signed with Texas in 2023. After sitting two years while backing up Quinn Ewers, another 5-star whose career never matched expectations, Manning is 16-4 as the starter but very few of the winning starts have earned spectacular reviews. Three of the four losses are to unranked teams including a pair of blemishes at the hands of Florida.

Full story: gatorbaitmedia.com/post/jones-vs-philo-and-other-qb-perceptions-realities

BEST SHOTS

From Florida 27, No. 7 Texas 24, the last time out · Photos courtesy UAA and Hannah White (FloridaGators.com)



Sumrall in the locker room



Kanye Clark with the game-sealing fumble



Tramell Jones Jr. on the move



The defense swarms



The locker room after Austin

MASTHEAD

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PREGAME DESK, GRAPHICS AND PRODUCTION

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Statistics, rankings and betting lines: ESPN, with the DraftKings line via ESPN. Series history, broadcast information and availability reports: FloridaGators.com.

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Next up: Oklahoma in Gainesville, Saturday, Nov. 7, 7:45 p.m. ET, SEC Network.

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